SAFE | SAFE-18

Team Backlog and User Story Template

The team's work items and the standard structure for writing a story

Meridian Group

Programme Helios — Infrastructure and Platform Stack for AI GPU Compute at Scale

Field	Detail
Document title	Team Backlog and User Story Template
Document reference	*SAFE-18-HEL-T2-v1.0*
Project / Programme	*Helios Tranche 2 — Scale Build*
Version	*1.0*
Status	*Baselined*
Date	*18 Sep 2026*
Author	*D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager*
Owner	*Product Owner*
Approver	*Product Owner accepts stories; the team owns the estimate*
Classification	*Internal*
Retention	*7 years from programme closure*

Document control

Version history

Version	Date	Author	Summary of change
0.1	*04 Jun 2026*	*D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager*	*Initial draft*
0.2	*21 Jul 2026*	*D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager*	*Updated following workstream lead review*
1.0	*18 Sep 2026*	*D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager*	*Baselined at the Tranche 2 funding gate*

Reviewers

Name	Role	Review scope	Date reviewed
T. Nakamura, Chief Platform Architect	*Chief Platform Architect*	*Technical content and solution alignment*	*08 Sep 2026*
L. Haddad, CISO	*CISO*	*Security, assurance and residency content*	*10 Sep 2026*
C. Whitfield, Finance Business Partner	*Finance Business Partner*	*Cost, funding and benefit figures*	*11 Sep 2026*
M. Verity, Head of P3O	*Head of P3O*	*Governance standards and completeness*	*15 Sep 2026*

Approval

This product is baselined once approval is recorded below. Any subsequent change must go through change control.

Name	Role	Decision	Date
R. Al Mazrouei, Group CTO	*Senior Responsible Owner / Group CTO*	*Approved*	*18 Sep 2026*
H. Farrell, Director of Infrastructure	*Director of Infrastructure*	*Approved*	*18 Sep 2026*
L. Haddad, CISO	*CISO*	*Approved subject to closure of ISS-003*	*18 Sep 2026*

Related products

Reference	Product	Relationship
SAFE-14	Feature Definition	Stories decompose from features
SAFE-19	Definition of Done	The completion standard
SAFE-20	Iteration Planning and Review Record	Where stories are committed

How to use this template

Aspect	Guidance
Purpose	Provides the standard for writing user stories and enabler stories, the criteria a story must meet before it enters an iteration, and the register of the team backlog.
Framework	SAFe — Team and Technical Agility — Team Backlog
Created when	At team formation; maintained continuously
Reviewed / updated	At every backlog refinement session
Owner	Product Owner
Approver	Product Owner accepts stories; the team owns the estimate
Format options	Document, presentation, register entry, or tool record — the content matters, not the medium.
Tailoring	Story format is a convention, not a rule. What matters is that the conversation happened and the acceptance criteria are agreed.

This is a worked example. Every field has been completed with illustrative content for Programme Helios, a fictional AI GPU infrastructure and platform programme. All example content is shown in grey italic — the black text is the template itself. Replace the grey italic content with your own.

Quality criteria

Use these to check the product is fit for purpose before submitting it for approval.

- Stories are independent, negotiable, valuable, estimable, small and testable
- Acceptance criteria are written before the story enters an iteration
- Stories are estimated by the people doing the work
- Enabler stories are visible in the backlog, not hidden inside feature work
- A story fits comfortably within one iteration; if it does not, split it

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1. Story format

Element	Format	Example
User story	As a <role>, I want <action>, so that <benefit>	As a SOC analyst, I want alerts enriched with asset ownership, so that I can route them without a lookup
Enabler story	Technical work required to support future business value	Deploy the asset ownership API into the pre-production environment
Spike	Time-boxed investigation with a defined question and output	Determine whether the asset API can sustain 200 requests per second — output: a written recommendation

2. Definition of Ready

What must be true before a story can be pulled into an iteration.

- The story is understood by the team after a conversation with the Product Owner
- Acceptance criteria are written and agreed
- Dependencies are identified and either resolved or scheduled
- It is estimated and fits within a single iteration
- Any required test data, environment or access is available
- Non-functional expectations are stated where they apply

3. Story template

Copy this block per story if you are working outside an ALM tool.

Field	Detail
Story ID	*SAFE-18-HEL-T2-v1.0*
Title	*Helios Tranche 2 — Scale Build*
Type	User / Enabler / Spike
Parent feature	*Escalated to the Portfolio Board where it exceeds programme tolerance*
As a	*Agreed with the integration partner at design freeze, 15 Oct 2026*
I want	*Reflected in the solution intent as a fixed constraint*
So that	*Delegated to the Programme Manager within the agreed tolerance*
Estimate (points)	*25*
Iteration	*Constrained by the 6.2 MVA site limit at DXB-1 until 2028*
Owner	*D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager*

4. Acceptance criteria

Ref	Given	When	Then
AC-01	*Storage sustains 1.2 TB/s against a representative training corpus for 30 minutes*	*23 Apr 2027*	*Independent penetration test closed with no open critical or high findings*
AC-02	*No unsigned container image can be admitted; every attempt is alerted within 30 seconds*	*31 Mar 2027*	*Fair-share quota holds within 5% for each tenant under contention*
AC-03	*No unsigned container image can be admitted; every attempt is alerted within 30 seconds*	*26 Feb 2027*	*No unsigned container image can be admitted; every attempt is alerted within 30 seconds*
AC-04	*Coolant leak alerts the NOC within 60 seconds and isolates the affected rack*	*31 Jan 2027*	*Coolant leak alerts the NOC within 60 seconds and isolates the affected rack*

5. Team backlog register

ID	Story	Type	Feature	Points	Priority	Iteration	Status
ST-4101	*As a platform administrator, I want to define a fair-share quota per tenant, so that no tenant can starve another during contention*	*User*	*FE-101*	*5*	*Medium*	*Iteration 1*	*Not started*
ST-4102	*As a researcher, I want my job to queue with a visible position and estimated start, so that I can plan my work*	*User*	*FE-101*	*3*	*Must have*	*Iteration 2*	*Open*
ST-4103	*Deploy the quota controller to the staging cluster with policy loaded from Git*	*Enabler*	*FE-101*	*3*	*Should have*	*Iteration 1*	*In progress*
ST-4104	*Determine whether checkpoint-and-resume can be achieved without framework changes — output: a written recommendation*	*Spike*	*FE-102*	*2*	*High*	*Iteration 1*	*Complete*
ST-4105	*As a security engineer, I want unsigned images refused at admission, so that only verified software runs on the estate*	*User*	*FE-105*	*5*	*Medium*	*Iteration 2*	*Not started*
ST-4106	*As a finance business partner, I want a monthly consumption export per tenant, so that I can raise internal recharges*	*User*	*FE-103*	*3*	*Must have*	*Iteration 3*	*Open*
ST-4107	*Enable DCGM exporters on all nodes and ship metrics to the observability platform*	*Enabler*	*FE-109*	*3*	*Should have*	*Iteration 2*	*In progress*

ID	Story	Type	Feature	Points	Priority	Iteration	Status
ST-4108	*As an operations engineer, I want a coolant leak to page the NOC within 60 seconds, so that racks are isolated before hardware is damaged*	*User*	*FE-111*	*5*	*High*	*Iteration 3*	*Complete*
ST-4109	*As a vendor support engineer, I want scoped break-glass access, so that I can diagnose faults without standing privilege*	*User*	*FE-112*	*8*	*Medium*	*Iteration 4*	*Not started*
ST-4110	*Migrate the image registry storage tier to sustain continuous DR replication*	*Enabler*	*FE-104*	*5*	*Must have*	*Iteration 4*	*Open*

6. Story splitting patterns

Use these when a story will not fit an iteration.

Pattern	How	Example
Workflow steps	Deliver one step of the flow at a time	Submit request now; approval flow next
Business rule variations	One rule per story	Standard access first; privileged access next
Happy path first	Defer error and edge cases	Successful enrolment first; failure handling next
Data variations	One data type or source per story	One log source, then the rest
Interface variations	One channel at a time	API first, then the console
Defer performance	Make it work, then make it fast	Functional first; the 200 rps NFR next